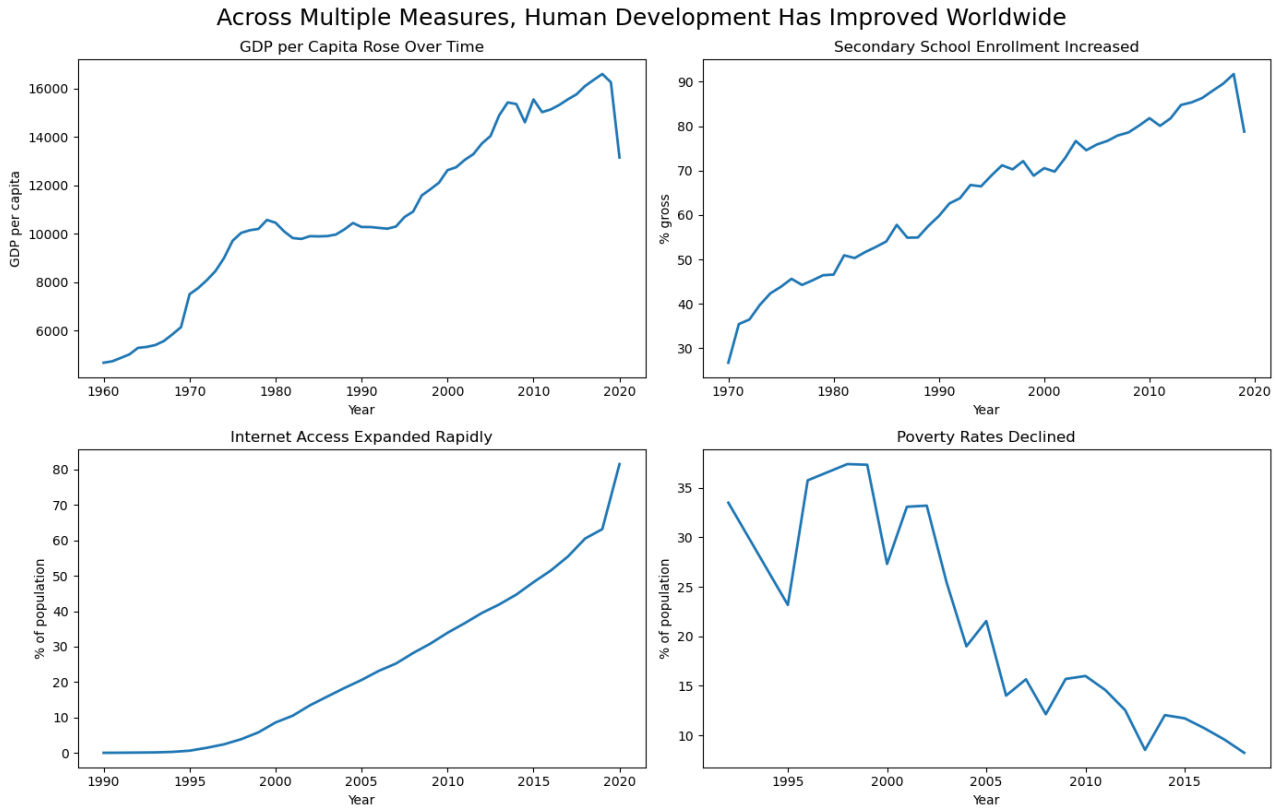
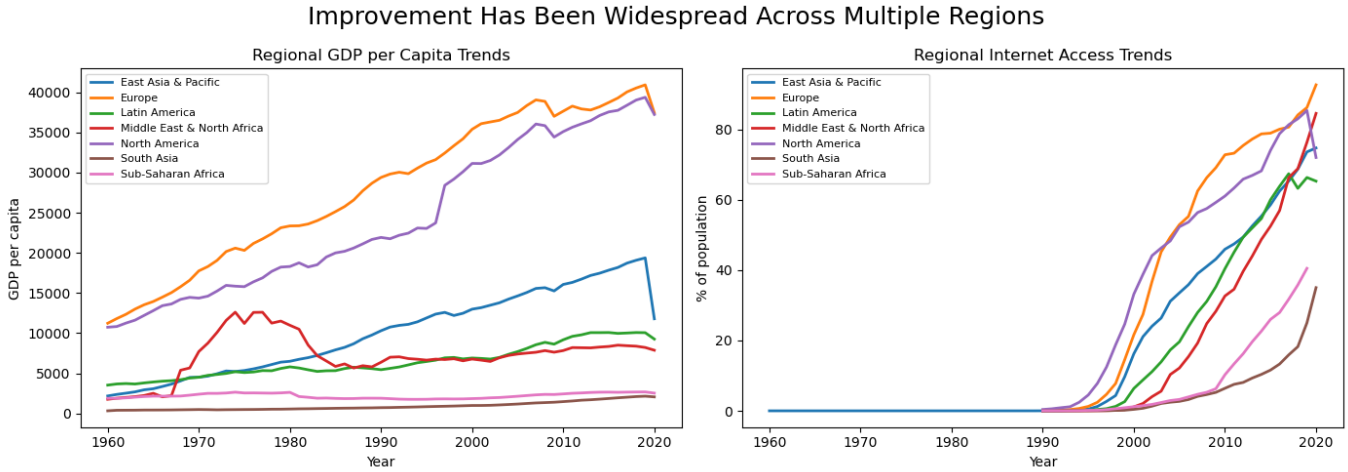
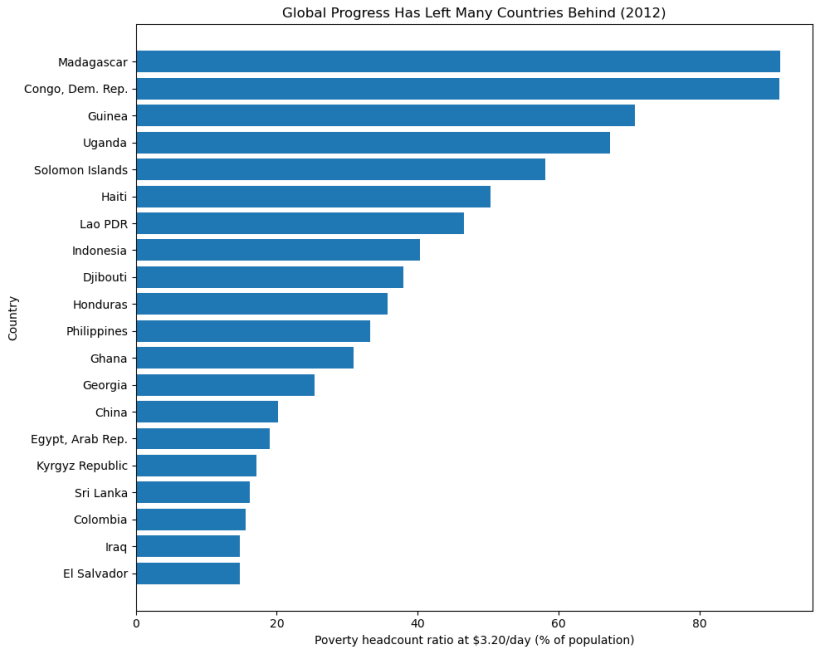
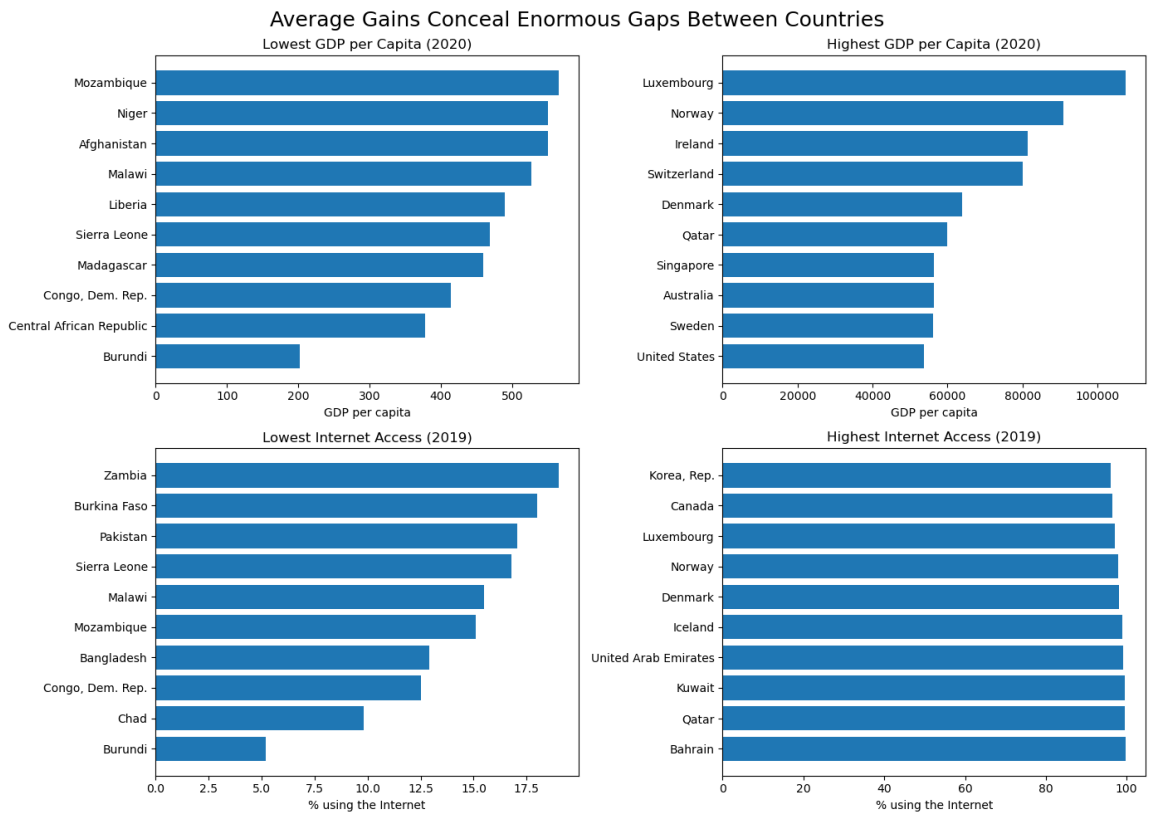

Across Multiple Measures, Human Development Has Improved Worldwide
GDP per Capita Rose Over Time
GDP per capita
Year
Secondary School Enrollment Increased
% gross
Year
Internet Access Expanded Rapidly
% of population
Year
Poverty Rates Declined
% of population
Year


Improvement Has Been Widespread Across Multiple Regions
Regional GDP per Capita Trends
GDP per capita
Year
East Asia & Pacific
Europe
Latin America
Middle East & North Africa
North America
South Asia
Sub-Saharan Africa
Regional Internet Access Trends
% of population
Year
East Asia & Pacific
Europe
Latin America
Middle East & North Africa
North America
South Asia
Sub-Saharan Africa


Global Progress Has Left Many Countries Behind (2012)
Madagascar
Congo, Dem. Rep.
Guinea
Uganda
Solomon Islands
Haiti
Lao PDR
Indonesia
Djibouti
Honduras
Philippines
Ghana
Georgia
China
Egypt, Arab Rep.
Kyrgyz Republic
Sri Lanka
Colombia
Iraq
El Salvador
Country
0
20
40
60
80
Poverty headcount ratio at $3.20/day (% of population)


Average Gains Conceal Enormous Gaps Between Countries
Lowest GDP per Capita (2020)
Mozambique
Niger
Afghanistan
Malawi
Liberia
Sierra Leone
Madagascar
Congo, Dem. Rep.
Central African Republic
Burundi
0
100
200
300
400
500
GDP per capita
Highest GDP per Capita (2020)
Luxembourg
Norway
Ireland
Switzerland
Denmark
Qatar
Singapore
Australia
Sweden
United States
0
20000
40000
60000
80000
100000
GDP per capita
Lowest Internet Access (2019)
Zambia
Burkina Faso
Pakistan
Sierra Leone
Malawi
Mozambique
Bangladesh
Congo, Dem. Rep.
Chad
Burundi
0.0
2.5
5.0
7.5
10.0
12.5
15.0
17.5
% using the Internet
Highest Internet Access (2019)
Korea, Rep.
Canada
Luxembourg
Norway
Denmark
Iceland
United Arab Emirates
Kuwait
Qatar
Bahrain
0
20
40
60
80
100
% using the Internet

- **Proposition:** Global human development has improved substantially over time.
- **Figures 1 and 2:** These persuade that the proposition is **true** by showing broad progress in GDP per capita, school enrollment, internet access, and poverty reduction.
- **Figures 3 and 4:** These persuade that the proposition is **not fully true** by emphasizing high-poverty countries and large gaps in GDP and internet access.
- **Which side I lean toward:** I lean more toward **Figures 3 and 4** because they highlight inequality hidden by averages.
- **Techniques in Figures 1 and 2:**
  - Using averages
  - Using a long time span
  - Choosing indicators with positive trends
  - Using optimistic titles
- **Techniques in Figures 3 and 4:**
  - Using single-year snapshots
  - Focusing on extreme cases
  - Highlighting worst-performing countries
  - Using skeptical titles